actions such as the Belt and Road Initiative and the Ladakh crisis may have pushed India closer to the US. China is therefore torn on how to deal with India, just as India is still somewhat divided on quite how close it wants to get to the US once the Ladakh situation stabilizes.

Having said that, an India–US alignment against China seems inescapable in the years ahead. If India and China were not in conflict over the border, they might have teamed up against the US: a balance-of-power logic would seem to suggest that two weaker powers would combine against the more powerful. Yet this has never really happened. The border conflict has ensured that global balance-of-power considerations have been trumped by bilateral differences. Even if the border conflict were resolved, the power gap between neighbouring India and China would likely push Delhi towards Washington – for the simple reason that China's power is on India's doorstep and therefore much more threatening than US power.

The only way the India–US partnership might be disrupted is if China and the US were to call a truce or decide to run the world together. The Australian strategist Hugh White's well-known book *The China Choice* is subtitled: *Why America Should Share Power*. White proposes a power-sharing future between a rising China and a declining US as a way of stabilizing Asia.[8] If that were to happen, India would be left to face China on its own, unless the power-sharing deal included a Chinese commitment to leave India alone. How likely is a China–US rapprochement? The general view all over the world is that rapprochement is unlikely given the hardening of US views across the political divide in Washington. If so, in addition to their negative perceptions of each other and differences over their perimeters, India's partnership with the US will constitute a third layer of friction between Delhi and Beijing, for as long as we can see into the future.

Power